

Unusual entrepreneur ACCELERATORS

success MANTRA

You cannot be
successful alone.
Prosperity and power
have to be shared

turning POINT

In 1991, when Punjab
government roped him
in for a spindle mill as a
joint venture

ride in STYLE

Gupta rides the
X-Trail SUV and the
Mercedes S-Class



VIKRAM SHARMA

RAJINDER
GUPTA

49, TEXTILE MANUFACTURER
CEO & MANAGING DIRECTOR, TRIDENT GROUP
INITIAL INVESTMENT IN 1985 Rs 3 crore
CURRENT TURNOVER Rs 2,100 crore

THREADS OF INSPIRATION

In business schools across Punjab, he is cited as a textbook example of homegrown entrepreneurship. With a flagship business in textiles, Rajinder Gupta's Rs 2,100-crore Trident Group is among the world's top five terry towel manufacturers and is a leading vendor for retail majors including WalMart, JCPenny and Luxury and Linen. Yet, he says, "The numbers don't drive me. I am only a custodian of what the system and the society has gifted me. I would rather measure my success by the yardstick of what I give them back." The state's single largest employer of 1,500-odd women, mostly rural girls, he uses a mélange of locally-produced raw materials in a diverse business portfolio comprising textile, paper, chemicals, energy, IT and pharmaceuticals to benefit 20,000 families. "Power and prosperity are best shared," says Gupta, who was born to a small-time cotton trader, and started by earning Rs 30 a day doing

odd jobs like making cement pipes and candles.

Gupta's business took off when in 1985 he set up a fertiliser manufacturing plant on a licence granted by his patrons in the Union government. A major break came in 1991, when the state, then under the governor's rule, roped him in for a joint venture, a spindle mill at Barnala, then a hotbed of terrorism. He took several risks in the turbulent 1980s, establishing industries at a time when capital was fleeing the state. As a self-made and the most-successful first-generation entrepreneur, Gupta is reckoned among his contemporaries as Punjab's Dhirubhai Ambani. He has been equally ingenious in setting up Takshila, an in-house platform that grooms fresh trainees, mostly gawky youngsters from little Punjab. His own experience as a ninth grader who had to drop out of school to help his family should be lesson enough for them.

by Ramesh Vinayak

GUPTA TAKES
PRIDE IN SPOTTING
AND NURTURING

TALENT. HIS
RS 400-CRORE
TERRY TOWEL
UNIT IS HEADED
BY A 30-YEAR-OLD
WHO IS FOUR
YEARS OLD IN
THE COMPANY.